BUILD YOUR AI CEO — THE COMPLETE SETUP GUIDE

API Key Setup Guide

MODULE 2 — Anthropic & OpenAI

Companion PDF for Module 2, Videos 1 & 2

MODULE 2 · API KEY SETUP

Beginner Edition | Mac & Windows | Step-by-Step

Your complete guide to creating Anthropic and OpenAI accounts, funding your API access, and securing your keys — ready for Module 4.

CYRUSHQ.AI

MODULE 2 OVERVIEW

Welcome to Module 2!

Creating your AI provider accounts and API keys — ready for Module 4 installation.

You've created the foundation of your AI CEO: its identity, personality, business knowledge, and operating instructions. Now it's time to prepare the artificial intelligence that will power it.

In this module, you'll create accounts with two AI providers:

VIDEO 1 — ANTHROPIC (CLAUDE)

You'll create your Anthropic account, activate API billing, purchase credits if needed, and generate your Claude API key.

VIDEO 2 — OPENAI

You'll create an OpenAI API account, set up billing, and generate a second API key that gives you access to another family of AI models.

✅ **DON'T WORRY**

If you've never done anything like this before — we'll walk you through every step.

⚠️ **IMPORTANT**

You're **not** installing OpenClaw or connecting these keys to your AI CEO just yet. That happens in Module 4. Your goal today is to have your provider accounts funded, your API keys created, and your credentials saved securely so they're ready when you need them.

First — What Exactly Is an API Key?

Think of an API key like a special digital access card. It allows software, such as OpenClaw, to communicate with an AI provider on your behalf.

HOW IT WORKS

- Your AI CEO sends a request to Claude
- Claude processes the request
- Claude sends a response back to your AI CEO
- Your API key identifies which authorized account is making the request

KEY CONCEPT

An API key is not the AI model itself. It's the credential that allows your system to access the provider.

🔐 SECURITY

API keys are **private**. Anyone who obtains a working key may be able to make requests billed to your account. That's why we'll treat your keys like passwords.

Before You Begin

Make sure you have:

- A computer with internet access
- A web browser (Chrome, Safari, or Edge)
- An email address you can access
- A payment method, if your account requires one
- A secure password manager where you can save your API keys
- Approximately 20–30 minutes to complete both setups

✅ GOOD NEWS

You do **not** need to open Terminal for this module. We'll use Terminal later, when we install OpenClaw in Module 4.

⚠ IMPORTANT

API billing is separate from your AI subscriptions. A paid ChatGPT or Claude subscription does not automatically mean your API account has a usable balance. API services have their own billing arrangements. Some accounts use prepaid credits. Others may have eligible included credits or invoicing arrangements. We'll show you how to check.

PART 1 — VIDEO 1

Create Your Anthropic (Claude) API Key

Anthropic is the company behind Claude — the primary AI model used in our foundational AI CEO setup.

STEP 1 — Create Your Anthropic Account

WEBSITE

`console.anthropic.com`

1. Open your web browser
2. Click the address bar at the top of the screen
3. Type `console.anthropic.com` and press **Enter**
4. Select **Sign Up** if you don't already have an account
5. Follow the on-screen instructions to create your account
6. Verify your email address if requested
7. Complete any additional account or organization setup questions

If you already have an Anthropic Console account, select **Log In** instead.

✅ **WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE**

Once signed in, you should reach the **Anthropic Console dashboard** — where you'll manage your API keys, billing, and usage.

Important: The Claude chat website and the Anthropic API Console serve different purposes. For this course, you need access to the **API Console**.

STEP 2 — Activate Billing and Add API Credits

⚠️ **THIS STEP IS EXTREMELY IMPORTANT!**

Creating an API key does not automatically mean your account has money available to use Claude. Most Anthropic API organizations use prepaid credits. These credits pay for your AI's usage.

What are tokens?

Tokens are small units of text that AI providers use to measure processing. You don't need to purchase individual tokens — instead, you add money to your API account, and the provider deducts the cost of the tokens your AI uses.

💡 Think of **API credits as fuel** for your AI CEO.

How to set up billing

1. While signed in to the Anthropic Console, find **Settings**
2. Open **Billing**
3. If prompted, enter your billing details and add a payment method
4. Look for your available API credit balance
5. If your balance is zero, select **Buy Credits**
6. Enter the amount you'd like to purchase and review the details
7. Confirm your purchase
8. Return to Billing and verify that your available balance has updated

💰 **HOW MUCH SHOULD YOU START WITH?**

For initial installation, learning, and testing, we suggest starting with approximately **$10–$20 in Anthropic API credits**, provided that amount meets the provider's current purchase requirements.

This is only a suggested starting balance — not a guaranteed monthly cost. Your actual usage depends on the model, conversation length, tools enabled, and how frequently your AI CEO operates. You can add more credits later.

Should you turn on automatic reload?

For beginners, we recommend **leaving auto-reload off initially**, unless you understand the charges and want uninterrupted service. You can enable it later.

⚠ **IMPORTANT**

Adding credits and setting a spending limit are **two different actions**. A spending limit does not necessarily add money to your account. Before moving on, confirm that your Anthropic API account has usable credits or an active billing arrangement.

STEP 3 — Create Your Anthropic API Key

Now that your account is ready, let's create your API key.

1. In the Anthropic Console, locate and click **API Keys**
2. Select **Create Key** or the equivalent button
3. If asked to choose a workspace, select the workspace for your AI CEO
4. Give the key a recognizable name

✅ **SUGGESTED KEY NAME**

```
OpenClaw-AI-CEO
```

6. Click **Create** or **Create Key** to confirm

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

Anthropic will generate a long string of characters — this is your private API key. It may begin with characters similar to:

```
sk-ant-
```

The exact format may vary.

STEP 4 — Copy and Securely Save Your Anthropic Key

⚠️ **CRITICAL**

Your full API key may only be displayed once. Don't close the window until you've securely saved it.

1. Find the newly generated API key on your screen
2. Click the **Copy** button next to it
3. Open your password manager
4. Create a new secure entry named: **Anthropic API Key — AI CEO**
5. Paste your API key into the password or secure-notes field
6. Save the entry
7. Confirm that you can retrieve the saved key

EXAMPLE OF WHAT A KEY MIGHT LOOK LIKE

```
sk-ant-EXAMPLE-THIS-IS-NOT-A-REAL-KEY
```

This is a fake example. It will not work. Your actual key will be different and considerably longer.

🔐 **NEVER SHARE YOUR API KEY**

- In Discord, email, or a support forum
- In screenshots or troubleshooting messages
- In your AI CEO's Markdown files
- On a public website or GitHub repository

If you didn't save the key and closed the window: You may need to create a new one. Revoke the unused key if you no longer need it.

STEP 5 — Verify Your Anthropic Setup

Let's confirm everything is in order. You do **not** need Terminal for this check.

CHECK 1 — API KEY

Open the API Keys section. You should see the key you created listed by its name. The full secret value may no longer be visible — that's normal.

CHECK 2 — BILLING

Open the Billing section. Confirm your organization has a usable credit balance or another active API billing arrangement.

CHECK 3 — SECURE STORAGE

Open your password manager. Confirm you've saved the full Anthropic API key.

YOUR ANTHROPIC CHECKLIST

- ☐ My Anthropic Console account is created and I can log in
- ☐ My API billing is active
- ☐ I have usable API credits or another eligible billing arrangement
- ☐ My API key has been generated
- ☐ My API key is saved securely in my password manager
- ☐ I understand that I'll connect the key to OpenClaw in Module 4

⚠ WHAT WE HAVE AND HAVEN'T VERIFIED

We've confirmed that your account and key are prepared. We have **not** yet tested the key through OpenClaw — that will happen during installation in Module 4.

🎉 Video 1 Complete!

You've created your Anthropic API account, prepared your billing, and generated the key you'll use to connect Claude to your AI CEO.

Up next: Video 2 — OpenAI API Key Setup

PART 2 — VIDEO 2

Create Your OpenAI API Key

Your Anthropic account is prepared. Now we'll create an API key for OpenAI.

WHY TWO PROVIDERS?

- **Claude** will be our primary AI model during the foundational build
- **OpenAI** gives you access to another family of AI models for specialized tasks, alternative workflows, and future integrations
- You might use different models for different responsibilities

⚠ **IMPORTANT TO UNDERSTAND**

OpenAI is an **additional provider**, not a requirement for Claude to function. Your AI CEO does not automatically use both providers simply because you've created both keys. Each provider must be configured and selected for the tasks where you want to use it.

IS OPENAI REQUIRED?

For the foundational First Contact exercise, **Claude is sufficient**. We recommend completing the OpenAI setup if you want the additional flexibility taught in this course, but you can defer it if you prefer to begin with only one provider.

STEP 6 — Create Your OpenAI API Account

WEBSITE

`platform.openai.com`

1. Open your web browser and navigate to `platform.openai.com`
2. Select **Sign Up** if you don't have an account
3. Follow the instructions to create your account
4. Verify your email address if requested
5. Complete any required account or organization setup

If you already have an OpenAI Platform account, sign in.

✅ **WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE**

You'll reach the **OpenAI Platform dashboard** — where you can manage API keys, projects, billing, and usage.

⚠️ **IMPORTANT**

Your **ChatGPT subscription** and your **OpenAI API account** have **separate billing**. Having a paid ChatGPT plan does not automatically provide prepaid API credits.

STEP 7 — Set Up OpenAI Billing and Buy API Credits

Before your AI CEO can make paid OpenAI API requests, your account needs an eligible billing arrangement. New OpenAI API accounts generally use prepaid billing.

How to set up billing

1. While signed in to the OpenAI Platform, open **Billing**
2. If requested, select the organization you want to use
3. Choose **Add Payment Details** if no payment method exists
4. Enter your billing information
5. Follow the prompts to purchase your initial API credits
6. Review the amount and Auto-reload setting carefully before confirming
7. Complete the purchase
8. Return to Billing and verify your credit balance is available

💰 **HOW MUCH SHOULD YOU PURCHASE?**

For initial setup and occasional supplemental use, we suggest starting with **$5–$10 in OpenAI API credits**. OpenAI's minimum initial prepaid purchase is typically $5, though requirements may change.

⚠️ **VERY IMPORTANT — CHECK AUTO-RELOAD**

OpenAI may offer to automatically purchase additional credits when your balance runs low. **Auto-reload may be enabled by default.**

- If you do **not** want automatic purchases: turn Auto-reload **off** before confirming
- If you prefer auto-reloads: review the amount, balance threshold, and any monthly reload limit
- Remember: a reload limit controls automatic purchases, not necessarily all possible API spending

STEP 8 — Create Your OpenAI API Key

1. While signed in to the OpenAI Platform, locate **API Keys** (or go directly to `platform.openai.com/api-keys`)
2. If asked to select a project, choose the project for your AI CEO
3. Click **Create New Secret Key**
4. Give your key a recognizable name

✅ **SUGGESTED NAME**

```
OpenClaw-AI-CEO
```

6. If the interface offers permissions, choose only what's required. For beginners, the appropriate default is fine.
7. Click **Create Secret Key**

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

OpenAI will generate a private API key. It may begin with characters similar to:

```
sk-
```

Some keys include a project-related prefix. The exact format can vary.

STEP 9 — Copy and Securely Save Your OpenAI API Key

⚠️ **CRITICAL**

Your new OpenAI API key may **only be displayed once**. Save it before closing the window.

1. Locate your newly generated API key
2. Click **Copy**
3. Open your password manager and create a new secure entry
4. Name it: **OpenAI API Key — AI CEO**
5. Paste your API key into the secure field and save
6. Confirm that you can retrieve it later

EXAMPLE OF WHAT AN OPENAI KEY MIGHT LOOK LIKE

```
sk-EXAMPLE-THIS-IS-NOT-A-REAL-KEY
```

This is a fake example. Do not use it as your actual key.

🔐 **SECURITY RULES**

- Do not paste your OpenAI key into your AI CEO's Markdown files
- Do not share it in Discord, email, or screenshots
- Store it securely until Module 4

STEP 10 — Verify Your OpenAI Setup

CHECK 1 — API KEY

Return to the OpenAI Platform's API Keys page. Confirm the key you created is listed.

CHECK 2 — BILLING

Open the Billing section. Confirm your account has usable credits or an active API billing arrangement.

CHECK 3 — SECURE STORAGE

Open your password manager. Confirm you've securely saved the OpenAI API key.

YOUR OPENAI CHECKLIST

- ☐ My OpenAI Platform account is created and I can sign in
- ☐ My API billing is active
- ☐ I have usable API credits or another eligible billing arrangement
- ☐ My OpenAI API key has been generated
- ☐ My key is saved securely in my password manager
- ☐ I've reviewed my automatic recharge settings
- ☐ I understand that this key will be connected to OpenClaw later if I choose to use OpenAI

PART 3

What Happens to Your API Keys Next?

You've created the keys. Here's what comes next and exactly how you'll use them.

You may be wondering: *"I have both API keys. Where do I put them?"*

✅ **ANSWER**

For now, **leave them securely stored in your password manager**. You don't need to enter them into Terminal during Module 2.

In Module 4, we'll install OpenClaw

OpenClaw has a setup wizard that guides you through connecting an AI provider. During that process, you'll:

1. Choose your AI provider
2. Select the API key authentication method
3. Retrieve your saved API key from your password manager
4. Paste the key into the secure prompt when OpenClaw asks for it
5. Press Enter and complete the remaining setup steps
6. Test whether OpenClaw can communicate with the selected model

Example — What entering your key will look like

Suppose OpenClaw asks you for your Anthropic API key. Here's exactly what you'll do:

1. Open your password manager
2. Find your saved entry: **Anthropic API Key — AI CEO**
3. Copy the full API key
4. Return to Terminal
5. Click inside the Terminal window if needed
6. Paste your API key into the prompt
7. Press **Enter**

> ⚠️ **NOTE**
>
> Some Terminal prompts **hide what you type or paste**. You may not see your key appear on the screen — that's normal. Do not repeatedly paste the key simply because the characters are hidden. Wait for OpenClaw to process your entry.

🔐 **VERY IMPORTANT**

- Only enter the key when OpenClaw **explicitly requests it** during the appropriate authentication step
- Do **not** paste the key into an ordinary Terminal command prompt
- Do **not** paste it into Discord
- Do **not** include it in any Markdown file

WHAT ABOUT THE SECOND API KEY?

If you choose Claude as your primary model, you'll connect Anthropic during the foundational installation. Your OpenAI key remains safely stored until you explicitly configure OpenAI as an additional provider.

PART 4

Understanding API Costs

How much will your AI CEO cost to run?

API usage is generally billed based on how much processing the model performs. Costs depend on:

- How often you interact with your AI CEO
- How long your conversations are
- How much context and business information is processed
- Which AI model you choose
- How frequently automated tasks run
- Whether you use additional models or tools

Provider	Suggested Initial Credits	Purpose
Anthropic	$10–$20	Initial installation, testing, and early Claude usage
OpenAI	$5–$10	Optional supplemental model usage

✅ **OUR RECOMMENDATION**

- Start small and monitor your API usage
- Add credits as needed
- Review available spending controls and automatic reload settings
- As your AI CEO becomes more capable, adjust your budget accordingly

⚠️ **IMPORTANT**

Prepaid credits may expire under provider policies, and purchases may be nonrefundable. Review the provider's current terms before buying more credits than you expect to use.

PART 5

Troubleshooting

Common issues and how to resolve them.

Problem 1 — I Can't Find the API Keys Section

Provider dashboards change over time. If the menu looks different:

- Confirm you're signed in to the correct API platform
- Look for a section labeled API Keys, Keys, Developer, or Settings
- Check whether you need to select a project or organization
- Consult the provider's current help documentation

For OpenAI, you can try: `platform.openai.com/api-keys`

Problem 2 — I Created an API Key But Don't Have Any Credits

Creating a key and funding your account are separate steps. Return to the provider's Billing section, check your available balance, and purchase credits if using prepaid billing. **Adding a credit card does not automatically add a usable balance.**

Problem 3 — I Have a Paid ChatGPT or Claude Subscription

Consumer subscriptions and API billing are separate. You may still need to activate API billing. Check your API Console's available credit balance or billing arrangement.

Problem 4 — I Forgot to Copy My API Key

If the provider no longer displays the full key:

- Return to the API Keys page
- Create a replacement key
- Save the replacement securely
- Revoke the unused key when appropriate

Do not try to recover a secret by sharing screenshots or account details with strangers.

Problem 5 — My API Key Is Invalid (During Module 4)

- Check that you're using the correct provider's key
- Confirm the key hasn't been revoked
- Confirm your API account is active and has credits
- Make sure you copied the complete key without extra characters

Note: An invalid-key error and an insufficient-credit error are not necessarily the same problem.

Problem 6 — My API Credits Are Disappearing Quickly

- Return to your provider's usage dashboard
- Review which models and projects are consuming credits
- Check whether any automated workflows are running more often than expected
- Review your auto-reload settings
- If necessary, temporarily stop the affected automation or disable the relevant key while investigating

PART 6

API Key Security

Your API keys are valuable credentials. Treat them with the same care as passwords.

🔐 **FOLLOW THESE RULES**

- **Keep your keys private.** Never post them publicly or share them in screenshots.
- **Store them securely.** Use a reputable password manager.
- **Don't place them in your AI CEO's Markdown files.** Identity and business knowledge files are not credential-storage locations.
- **Don't upload them to GitHub.** Never commit API keys or secret files to public repositories.
- **Review your API usage regularly.** Unexpected usage can indicate an exposed credential or unintended automation.
- **Revoke compromised keys immediately.** If a key is exposed, revoke it, create a replacement, and update any systems using the old key.
- **Use separate keys when appropriate.** As your business grows, consider separate keys for testing and production.

💡 **A NOTE ABOUT TROUBLESHOOTING WITH CHATGPT OR GROK**

You can use ChatGPT or Grok to help interpret technical errors — but **never paste your actual API keys into those conversations**. Remove all sensitive information before asking for help.

FINAL MODULE 2 CHECKLIST

Confirm Everything Is Ready

Before moving to Module 3, verify each item below.

VIDEO 1 — ANTHROPIC

- ☐ Anthropic Console account created
- ☐ Billing configured
- ☐ Usable API credits confirmed
- ☐ Anthropic API key generated
- ☐ Key saved securely in password manager
- ☐ Auto-reload preferences reviewed

VIDEO 2 — OPENAI

- ☐ OpenAI Platform account created
- ☐ Billing configured (if using OpenAI)
- ☐ Usable API credits confirmed
- ☐ OpenAI API key generated
- ☐ Key saved securely in password manager
- ☐ Auto-reload preferences reviewed

SECURITY

- ☐ I have not shared my API keys
- ☐ My API keys are stored securely
- ☐ I understand that API credits pay for usage
- ☐ I understand that having an API key does not automatically connect a model to OpenClaw
- ☐ I know that I'll use my Anthropic key during OpenClaw setup in Module 4

🎉 Congratulations — Module 2 Complete!

You've prepared the AI provider accounts that will power your AI CEO. You now understand what API keys are, how API billing works, and how to keep your credentials secure.

WHAT'S NEXT?

- **Module 3** — Create your AI CEO's Discord command center
- **Module 4** — Install OpenClaw, connect your AI model, and add your personalized workspace files

You're one step closer to meeting your AI CEO! 🚀